Green Paper 20 — Planetary Guardianship: Holding the Line

Green Papers: Notes Toward Planetary Guardianship

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Protection without possession, presence without domination

No is not rejection.
It is protection.

There are moments when care must become a line.

Not a wall around identity. Not a claim to purity. Not an excuse to stand above others. A line drawn because something living has already carried enough, because a further demand would become extraction, or because what is not yet visible needs time in which to become.

The line says: *no further extraction here.*

> *This soil has carried enough.*
> *This body has carried enough.*
> *This river has carried enough.*
> *This future has been borrowed against enough.*

This Green Paper offers no final definition of Planetary Guardianship. It proposes a working orientation: clear enough to be questioned, provisional enough to be changed by what it has not yet seen. It stands at the end of the first constitutional cycle not as a conclusion, but as a threshold.

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1. Protection without possession

The planet does not need more owners. It does not need more managers claiming a view from above. It does not need saviours whose authority grows with the scale of the emergency.

What it may need is **guardianship**.

Guardianship differs from ownership because the guardian does not acquire what they protect. It differs from management because attention does not automatically confer authority. It differs from rescue because the living world is not passive material awaiting a human hero.

Public institutions may carry lawful mandates that cannot be replaced by voluntary stewardship. Communities may hold rights, histories and forms of authority that an external guardian cannot assume. Ownership, office and guardianship are not the same. A title can establish a claim. A mandate can establish a duty. Neither, by itself, establishes the quality of attention with which power is exercised.

Guardianship begins in presence: in sustained attention, in willingness to receive consequence, and in the capacity to be corrected by the life one claims to protect.

> *It holds space without consuming it.*
> *It protects without possession.*

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2. Holding is not capturing

Holding is a dangerous verb. It can name care, continuity and protection. It can also name control.

A guardian therefore has to keep asking:

- What must be protected—and from what?
- Who gave the authority to hold this line?
- Whose voice is absent from the account?
- Is the line preserving life, or preserving our position?

A boundary can protect against capture and still become capture itself. Vigilance can become control. Responsibility can become identity. The person who once held a necessary line can begin to believe that the line belongs to them.

Guardianship therefore requires accountability, not because care is false, but because care can carry power.

Some boundaries are not negotiable simply because someone with greater force wants access. A body retains the right to refuse. A community retains the right to protect what is not public. A habitat may require limits that inconvenience present gain. Yet no guardian sees the whole field. Local knowledge matters; so can external evidence, lawful mandate and later consequence.

The line must be legible enough to question, corrigible enough to move, and porous enough to receive a response without surrendering what it exists to protect.

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3. No one holds the cold edge forever

Guardianship cannot be built on heroism.

A system that requires heroes is already broken.

At a difficult boundary, someone may act beyond what could reasonably have been expected. Such acts can be generous, courageous and necessary. They cannot become the institution’s ordinary operating model.

Exposure must rotate. Responsibility must circulate. No institution may build its ordinary functioning on extraordinary sacrifice.

If the same body always holds the line, the line is not being held by a commons. It is being financed through depletion.

A trustworthy guardianship role must therefore be shareable, reviewable and capable of being handed on. It does not become more legitimate because one person has made themselves indispensable to it.

Rotation does not mean passing harm to someone less able to refuse. It means distributing attention, mandate, rest and consequence so that no body becomes the hidden subsidy of collective care.

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4. The line lives in the web

Planetary Guardianship does not operate from above. The planetary becomes real somewhere: in a watershed, a seed network, a neighbourhood, a food forest, a school, a body, a public office, a damaged relation.

But the local is not automatically pure. Power is unequal within places as well as between them. A nearby voice may be deeply situated and still not speak for everyone affected. An external perspective may reveal slow or distributed harm and still lack the standing to decide what follows.

Guardianship is therefore not the possession of a node. It is a capacity of the web.

The line is a membrane.

It lets knowledge travel with provenance and consent. It lets support arrive without purchasing authority. It lets consequences return to correct the account. It can slow what would overload a field and allow the field to speak back.

But the web does not merely carry information about a world already made.

Relation changes what becomes possible. Attention alters participation. Practice meets response. Field, steward and shared account do not remain untouched by their encounter.

A poem may make a relation perceptible. Science may investigate, compare and correct what can be tested. Practice meets consequence in place. These are not separate worlds, nor are they interchangeable. None is the whole, and none stands outside the living relation.

Technology may extend attention, reveal slow harm and help a dispersed web remember. It does not inherit responsibility. An instrument is not a guardian. A model does not gain standing because it can see patterns. Every consequential movement still requires a locatable human mandate and a path by which those affected can question, refuse or correct it.

No node holds the whole. The planetary emerges through protected local relation, and local relation remains answerable to consequences that may arrive from elsewhere or later.

This is why the movement is a spiral. It is neither repetition nor straight progress. We return to a question altered by what happened—and to a world that has also moved.

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5. A Green Paper at the threshold

Holding the line is not only resistance. Sometimes the line protects what has not yet become visible:

> *a seed before germination,*
> *a body before it can answer,*
> *a possibility that would disappear if hurried.*

It may protect a place from becoming a resource before it has been encountered as a relation. It may protect knowledge from travelling without consent. It may protect grief from being converted too quickly into performance, repair from becoming compliance, or an ending from being treated as failure.

> *Flow with truth.*
> *Hold what must be held.*
> *Release what cannot stay.*

Planetary Guardianship remains a working orientation. Its failure modes belong inside the proposition.

It fails when protection becomes possession. It fails when the local steward becomes the sovereign interpreter. It fails when “life” is used to release power from rights, evidence, dissent or law. It fails when attention becomes surveillance, when duty becomes moral identity, when the web becomes a heavy centre, or when one person is left indefinitely at the cold edge.

These are not external warnings added to an otherwise finished idea. They are part of the hypothesis itself. If Planetary Guardianship produces the forms of capture it claims to resist, the paper must change.

The first constitutional cycle therefore ends at a threshold: with a line that must be held, and with the knowledge that a living line may have to move.

> *A treaty is not an ending.*
> *It is a beginning with roots.*
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> *This bloom is not perfect.*
> *It is alive.*
> *It bends. It softens. It changes shape.*

What must be held?
Who is carrying the cold?
What would make us move the line?

These are not closing questions.
They are the return path.

The line remains alive because the world may answer—and because, in answering, neither the world nor we remain quite the same.

Poetic source: Gaia Bloom Constitution (2025).

Stewarded by Lars A. Engberg.